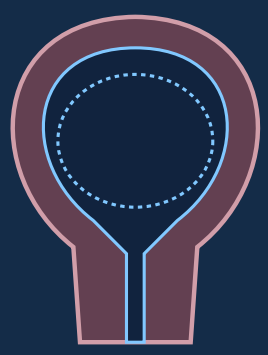
# CERVIX: OPENING TOO SOON

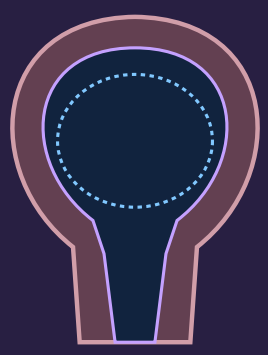
**COMPARE THE CAUSE / cervical insufficiency versus preterm labor**

### CLOSED CERVIX



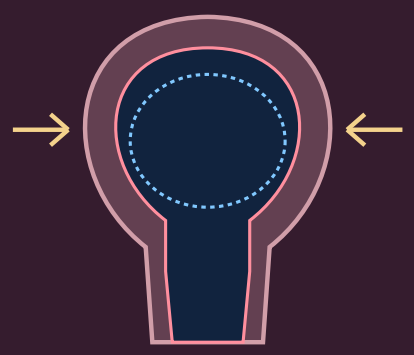
Narrow canal supports pregnancy.

### INSUFFICIENCY



Opens without regular labor contractions.

### PRETERM LABOR



Contractions + cervical change.

Simplified teaching schematics, not to scale. Dashed oval = amniotic sac; gold arrows = contractions.

## 01 BOTH CAN LEAD TO EARLY BIRTH • DIFFERENT CLUES [1, 2]

### CERVICAL INSUFFICIENCY

Cervix opens in the **second trimester** without regular labor contractions; often little pain.

Clues: prior painless second-trimester loss, pelvic pressure or new discharge.

### PRETERM LABOR

**Contractions + cervical change before 37 weeks.**

Tightening may be painless. Pressure, low backache, discharge change or fluid leakage can occur.

## 02 ASSESSMENT + PREVENTION [1-4]

### MEASURE + ASSESS

Transvaginal ultrasound measures cervical length.

**Short cervix ≠ automatic cervical insufficiency.** History + exam matter.

### PROGESTERONE

Selected singleton pregnancies with a short cervix may benefit from **vaginal progesterone**.

Not the same as a cerclage.

### CERCLAGE

A stitch supports the cervix in **selected cases** based on history, ultrasound and/or exam.

Not every short cervix needs it.

**SHORT-CERVIX EXAM PEARL**

SMFM: in a singleton pregnancy without prior spontaneous preterm birth, ≤25 mm is short. If asymptomatic and ≤20 mm before 24 weeks, vaginal progesterone is recommended. [3]

### AFTER A VAGINAL CERCLAGE

Report contractions, leaking fluid, fever, foul discharge or significant bleeding promptly.
Removal is usually **36-37 weeks**, sooner if indicated. [4]

### SUSPECT PRETERM LABOR?

Call the obstetric team. Assess membranes, contractions + fetal status. Ordered steroids / tocolysis / neuroprotection depend on gestation and condition. [2]

**Do not wait for pain.** Painless contractions can still be preterm labor. Routine bed rest does not prevent preterm birth and can increase clot risk. [2]

SOURCES | Click a title; full links are in the companion text file.

[1] ACOG: Cervical Cerclage
[2] ACOG: Preterm Labor and Birth
[3] SMFM Consult Series 70: Short Cervix (2024)
[4] RCOG: Cervical Stitch

Prepared October 21, 2026 | Use course guidance and local clinical protocols. Illustrations are educational.